

UNIT 1.- THE ANCIEN RÉGIME AND THE ENLIGHTENMENT

1.-ANCIEN RÉGIME or OLD SYSTEM.- Political and social system which emerged in Europe during the Early Modern Age and lasted till 18th century. Its main characteristics were:

	POLITICS	ECONOMY	SOCIETY
	Absolute monarchy	Agricultural economy	Estates of realm

2.-MONARCHY DURING THE EARLY MODERN AGE(16th and 17th centuries)

In this period there were three types of monarchy: authoritarian monarchies, absolute monarchies and parliamentary monarchies.

2.1.- Authoritarian monarchy



Monarchs in the 16th century are considered as “authoritarian” because they had forced the nobility to accept their authority. However, these monarchs also had to respect institutions that were able to limit their power, such as the Cortes in Spain or the Estates General in France.

Authoritarian monarchs implemented various measures in order to govern their kingdoms more effectively:

- They unified all the territories that were under their control.
- They established administrative unity for the entire kingdom.
- They created royal armies to end their dependence on the nobility for military support.

Examples of authoritarian monarchy: **CATHOLIC MONARCHS** , who established this political system in Spain.

2.2.-Absolute monarchy

In the 17th century , absolute monarchy came to predominate in Western Europe. It was called “absolute” because the crown had unlimited authority and it was believed to come from God.

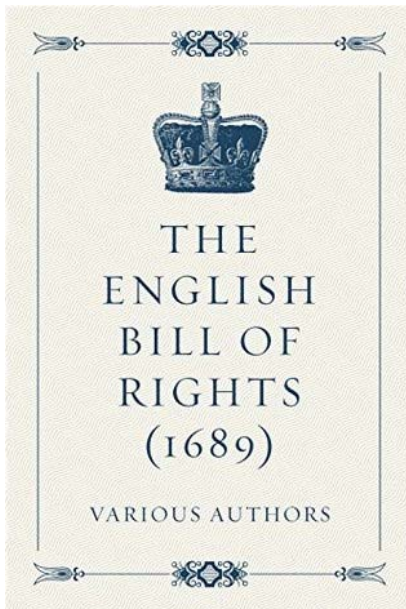


These monarchs:

- didn't allow representative bodies which could limit the crown's power to meet.
- controlled the government and economy of their kingdoms .
- they expanded the army to increase their control.

2.3.-Parliamentary monarchy

In England, there was a civil war in the 1640s between supporters of the king and supporters of Parliament, known as Parliamentarians. As a result, the absolute monarchy was replaced by a republic under the control of the former Parliamentarian commander Oliver Cromwell.



After Cromwell's death , the absolute monarchy was restored, but it only lasted until the Glorious Revolution of 1688. This led to the establishment of a parliamentary monarchy, in which the monarch's power were limited by Parliament.

The **Bill of Rights (1689)** established the need for regular parliaments, and stated that the monarch could not impose taxes without Parliament's consent.

3.-ECONOMY(16th and 17th centuries)

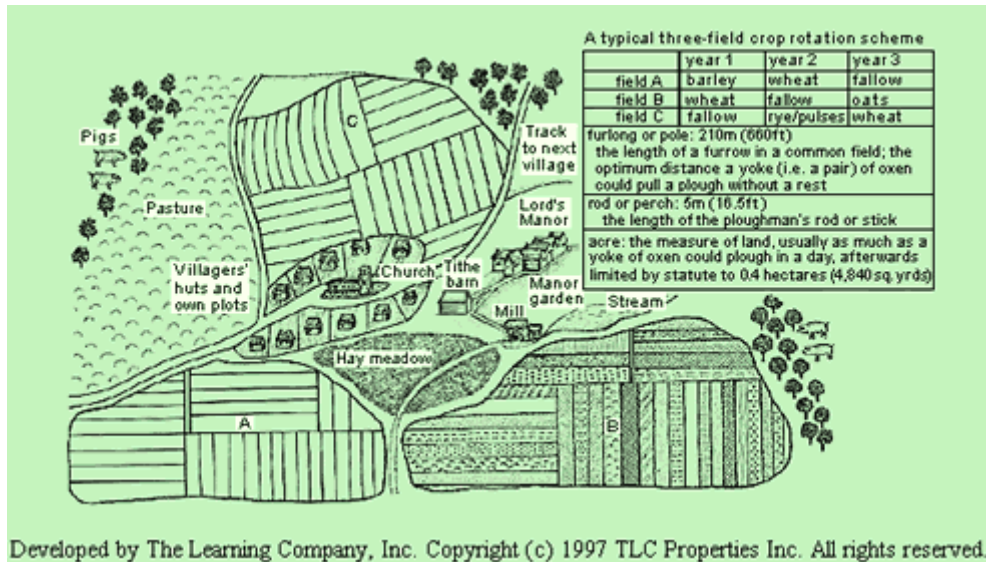
At the beginning of the Early Modern Age, the Ancien Régime economy was based on agriculture, craft production and trade. However, after the discovery of America, two new economic systems developed: commercial capitalism and mercantilism.

3.1.- AGRICULTURE

The most important activity in the 18th century was agriculture. Grains (bread, animal feed) were the main crops. It was mainly **subsistence farming**, based on a **three-year crop rotation system**. This type of farming produced just enough food for the population to survive on.

When crops failed (**subsistence crisis**), the situation for rural families became very difficult. Prices increased and with them, hunger and misery. Popular revolts occurred regularly in protests against this situation.

Most of the land belonged to the nobility and the clergy. In general, they did not pay taxes on their wealth. The rest of the population was made up of peasants who worked on the land that belonged to the nobility. In the towns and cities, there were also artisans and traders.



3.1.-

3.2.-COMMERCIAL CAPITALISM (The 16th century)

Europe experienced significant economic growth in the 16th century thanks to the discovery of the New World, which became an important new market for European exports. In this context, commercial capitalism developed. This was a new system that enabled private businesses to accumulate profits, especially through trade.

The following developments encouraged economic growth and the emergence of commercial capitalism:

- the emergence of new forms of craft production in workshops and through the domestic system.
- the establishment of banks, which facilitated commercial operations.
- new commercial and financial practices, such as accounting, bills of exchange and loans.

3.3.-MERCANTILISM (The 17th century)

During the 17th century, there was a serious economic crisis, caused mostly by the enormous amounts of gold and silver that arrived in Europe from America. An excess of these precious metals caused their value to fall, while prices increased.

Europe's absolute monarchs imposed a new economic system called **MERCANTILISM**, which was based on the idea that a country's wealth depended on how much gold and silver it possessed. In order to accumulate more of these precious metals, monarchs implemented protectionist policies to limit imports and encourage exports.

3.4.- DEMOGRAPHIC AND ECONOMIC GROWTH

The 18th century was a time of **population growth**: between 1650 and 1800, Europe grew from 100 to 200 million people. This was due to several factors: there were no major epidemics, new crops (such as potatoes and corn) were introduced and it was, on the whole, a peaceful century.

This growth led to an increase in demand for goods and services and resulted in intense economic growth.

New products were created and commercial companies sought new markets around the world in which to sell their products.

The movement of products was made possible by improvements to transport and communication networks. Trade was then able to grow between Europe, Africa and America.

4.-SOCIETY (16th and 17th centuries)

In the Early Modern Age, the estates of the realm continued to be the dominant form of social organization in Europe.

The First and the Second Estates (clergy and nobility) maintained their traditional privileges. They were exempt from paying tax to the crown, and they lived on the rent which they received from their lands, as well as the taxes which they collected from the peasantry. However, the lesser nobility and the lower clergy (rural priest and monks) were often poor.

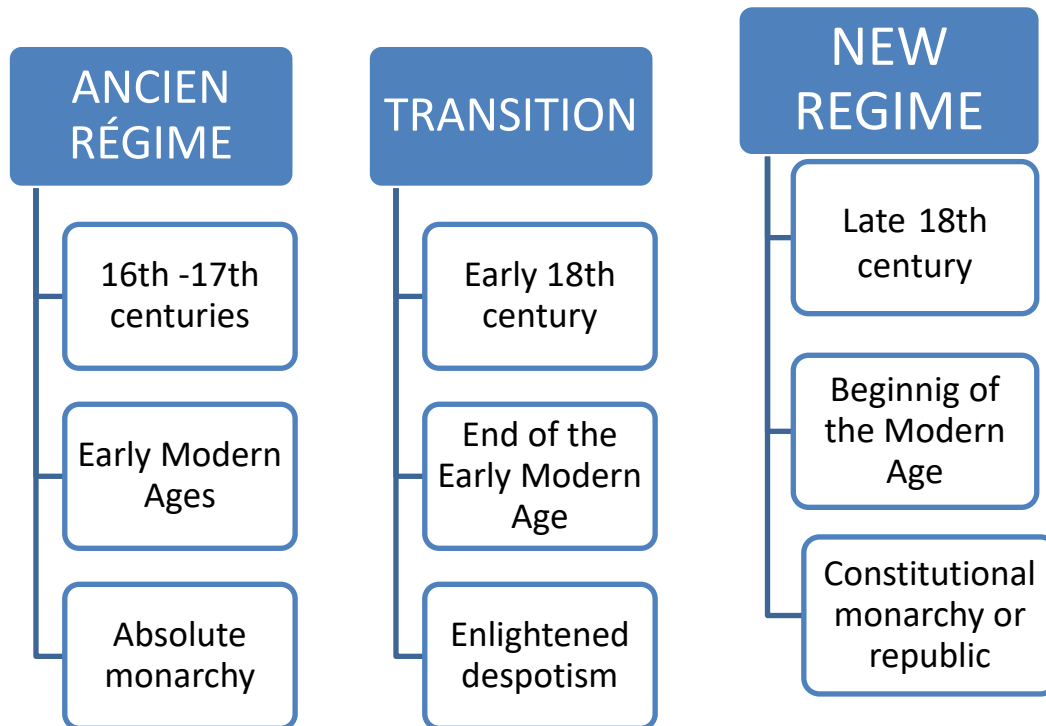
The Third Estates did not have any privileges and had to pay tax. However, during this period the differences between the various groups which were part of the Third Estate intensified.

- The upper middle class, or bourgeoisie-composed of prominent merchants and business owners-became richer and more powerful as the European economy prospered.
- The lower middle class, or petit bourgeoisie-composed mostly of small merchants and craftsmen-declined because they could not compete with new forms of production.



- The peasantry (poor farmers and labourers) suffered during the 17th century because of poor harvests, rising prices and the higher taxes which they had to pay to the crown, nobility and clergy.

FROM THE ANCIEN RÉGIME TO THE NEW REGIME



5.- THE ENLIGHTENMENT

The Enlightenment was an intellectual movement that developed in Europe during the 18th century. It criticized the Ancien Régime and its system of power and beliefs.

The Englishmen, John Locke and Isaac Newton has addressed some of its ideas in the 17th century: Locke defended the division of powers and Newton the scientific method as the only form of rational knowledge.

The age of Enlightenment was about understanding the world through the **reason**. It was a direct criticism of the religious basis of most Western societies, where the church exerted powerful social control.

According to Enlightenment thinking, the path to knowledge, the basis of happiness, was education. Enlightened thinkers believed inhuman progress and gradual improvement in the lives of human beings.

Great importance was also given to the value of tolerance. Tolerance was, thinkers said, complementary to reason, education and knowledge.

5.1.- The Philosophers of the Enlightenment

A group of French writers and philosophers defended freedom and equality in their books. Notable among them were Montesquieu, Voltaire, Diderot, Rousseau and d'Alembert. What they all had in common was their opposition to a society based on the estates of the realm; a society that was conditions by birth.

5.2.- Economic thinking

Until the age of Enlightenment, the most common economic trend was mercantilism, based on the accumulation of precious metals.

Enlightenment thinkers, however, defended physiocracy, which saw agriculture as the primary source of wealth, and economic liberalism. Both ways of thinking defended private property and the freedom of trade and industry.

5.3.- Political thought

Enlightenment thinkers wanted to create a government system that went beyond absolutism. This was called political liberalism. The main theorists were French, but the political scene in England was also a strong influence.

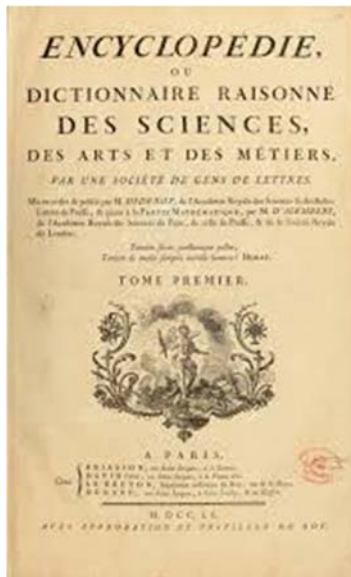


Montesquieu argued that the three branches of government (legislative, executive and judicial) should be independent. For him, justice that was truly separate from the other powers was a guarantee of freedom.

Rousseau stated that power came from a social contract between rulers and those governed. Citizens(the governed) should choose their representatives through voting.

Voltaire, for his part, insisted that Parliament was the best institution to limit the power of kings.

5.4.- The Encyclopaedia



In 1751, two French Enlightenment thinkers, **Diderot** and **D'Alembert**, published the first Encyclopaedia.

The Encyclopaedia was a great work containing all the knowledge of the time. The book helped spread Enlightenment ideas among Europe's bourgeoisie.

The Encyclopaedists were considered the representatives of the Enlightenment movement.

6.- THE COLLAPSE OF ABSOLUTISM

Towards the end of the 17th century, British politics experienced dramatic changes. At the same time, a series of reforms, known as **enlightened despotism**, spread throughout Europe.

6.1.- The English Revolution

Since Medieval times in England, the power of the monarch had been limited by the English Parliament. It had two Houses of Representatives. One of them was made up of the nobility and the clergy, and was called the **House of Lords**. The other was made up of the bourgeoisie and was called the **House of Commons**.

Whenever the monarchy wished to approve new taxes or declare war against another country, both houses had to meet and be consulted.

However, in 1642, King Charles I tried to rule without Parliament. Resistance by those who opposed the intentions of the king led the country into civil war. On the one side there were the supporters of Parliament and on the other, the absolute monarchy.

In 1649, King Charles I was executed and a Republic was proclaimed. However, the leader of the Republic, Oliver Cromwell, became a dictator. When he died in 1660, the monarchy was restored and Charles II was crowned.

Charles II had to accept the power of Parliament. In 1679 the Habeas Corpus Act was passed. This meant that everyone was entitled to a fair trial. In 1685 Charles II and James II became King. James was a Catholic and appointed several Catholics to high office. When Parliament protested, James II dissolved it.

Parliament invited William of Orange to overthrow James. When William led his army to London in 1688, James fled to France. The overthrow of James II is called the Glorious Revolution. William of Orange was offered the crown provided he accept the Bill of Rights that limited his power. Parliamentary monarchy was born.

6.2.- Enlightened Despotism

Most of the monarchies in the rest of Europe continued their absolutist rule. Some monarchs, like Maria Theresa of Austria, Catherine the Great of Russia and Charles III of Spain, introduced



some of the Enlightenment's proposals. This became known as **enlightened despotism**.

These included the modernisation of agriculture, certain educational reforms, the development of manufacturing and the liberalisation of trade.

The motto for enlightened despotism was **"everything for the people , nothing by the people"**. The idea of enlightened monarchs was to yield in some areas but to keep their power intact.

Over time it was shown that this could not be sustained for long. The process of a country's modernisation inevitably meant fundamental changes both in the hierarchical society and in

absolutism.